Digital citizenship and transformative learning: the role of radio and podcasts in school education

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In today's educational landscape, media literacy and digital citizenship skills represent key dimensions in preparing students to interact consciously and critically with digital media. These issues are intertwined with the Sustainable Development Goals of Agenda 2030, particularly Goal 4, which aims to ensure inclusive and equitable quality education by promoting learning opportunities for all. Radio and podcasts, traditionally considered classic communication tools, have taken on new meaning in the contemporary educational context thanks to the opportunities offered by digital and the European guidelines defined by the DigComp 2.2 framework, which identifies essential skills for digital citizenship (Cabero-Almenara et al., 2023). This study describes an experimental initiative developed in collaboration between the Learning Sciences Institute of the University of Foggia and the Istituto Comprensivo Dante Alighieri of Foggia.

The project aims to promote students' communication and media skills through an educational pathway centered on the use of audiovisual tools, integrating the development of technical skills with the enhancement of critical and creative abilities. This approach reflects theoretical perspectives found in the psycho-pedagogical literature, which highlight the transformative value of experiential learning (Berg et al., 2023) and the relevance of media literacy in the contemporary educational context (Cho et al., 2024). The central goal of the intervention is to raise students' awareness of the importance of communication in all its forms, with a focus on the digital and interpersonal dimensions. Using the radio context as a meaningful learning environment, the project develops technical skills, promotes critical content analysis skills, and values digital media as tools for active citizenship.

The intervention was structured in two main phases: the first phase, devoted to a theoretical-practical introduction, included an initial meeting with Unifg Web Radio staff to explore the history and educational goals of the project, followed by a technical workshop. During the workshop, students learned the use of microphones, mixers and audio editing software, acquiring fundamental technical skills for producing multimedia content. Through creative writing exercises, participants experimented with storytelling and content planning techniques, with an emphasis on interview construction. The second phase was devoted to the production of multimedia content: organized in teams, students worked on the creation of original podcasts, with the support of technical and teaching staff, in a collaborative environment geared toward active learning. The methodology adopted uses both a longitudinal and cross-sectional research design.

This embedded case study employs a longitudinal survey design to systematically monitor the intervention's effectiveness over time, analyzing through repeated measurements the progression of students' acquired competencies and the overall educational impact within the bounded system of the primary research site. Concurrently, following Yin's (2018) multiple-case study methodology, the experimental protocol will be replicated in three additional educational institutions in the Foggia area as embedded subunits, allowing for cross-sectional analysis to evaluate the generalizability and transferability of the model across heterogeneous educational contexts, thereby enhancing the analytical generalization and external validity of the study. For the collection of qualitative data on the educational experience within the case boundaries, focus groups were implemented with structured stimulus questions based on a validated framework, exploring students' perceptions of the educational impact through a phenomenological approach consistent with Stake's (1995) interpretive case study paradigm. Preliminary data analysis, conducted through methodological triangulation as recommended by Creswell and Poth (2018) for case study research, indicates that the intervention produced statistically significant effects ($p<0.05$) on the development of students' digital and communication skills within the specific context under examination.

Technical learning within this case setting resulted in the acquisition of procedural competencies related to audio production tools and methodologies, while the experiential approach stimulated critical thinking and creativity, as evidenced by the analysis of pre/post intervention assess-

ment rubrics designed specifically for this case. Students demonstrated a quantifiable increase in self-awareness regarding the value of communication as a tool for civic expression and participation, and the content produced reflects an in-depth understanding of the topics covered, demonstrating the effectiveness of the pedagogical approach in integrating theory and practice within the bounded case system. Furthermore, cooperative learning contributed to the enhancement of interpersonal skills and the establishment of collaborative dynamics, strengthening the sense of belonging and sharing, as detected through standardized Likert scale questionnaires administered at the beginning and conclusion of the educational program, providing rich, contextually-specific data characteristic of case study research methodology.

In line with McDougall and Rega's Theory of Change (2023), the project highlighted how transformative learning can result from the combination of technical development and civic awareness. This perspective integrates the acquisition of technical skills with students' personal and social development, promoting an educational model that prepares young people to become active and aware citizens. In addition, the skills developed reflect the goals set forth in the DigComp 2.2 framework, fostering the construction of a digital citizenship capable of meeting the challenges of contemporary society. Future prospects for the project include in-depth longitudinal evaluation to monitor the long-term impact of the educational pathway, as well as comparative studies in different school settings to further validate the proposed model. In addition, the introduction of emerging technologies, such as artificial intelligence, is planned to personalize the educational experience and enhance learning opportunities. A long-term goal is to create a network of schools and institutions that share educational practices based on the use of digital media as tools for citizenship and media literacy.

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